

## It always was so!

D Manjunath

Conversation among the regulars in the neighbourhood park is often a litany of laments about the state of politics, economics, and society. Political discussions centre around shifting opinions and affiliations of our leading leaders. Job-hops of youngsters is proxy for the state of the economy and of the mind of gen-next segueing into a roundup of the marital strains of the said young ones. A collective sigh bemoaning modern times and a conclusion that it once was better concludes the evening. Catching this exchange recently, led me to ask “Was it really different back then?” And recollect the following stories.

Keynes famously changed his theses so frequently during the writing of his magnum opus “A Treatise on Money” that he thought it was an artistic failure. However, he justified his flipflopping, with “when the facts change, I change my opinion.” Perhaps a useful line for our leaders, if they ever subject themselves to public scrutiny that is.

Job hopping by the peripatetic scientist-philosophers in the golden age of science, even as they laid its foundation, is legendary. Boltzmann, who gave us statistical mechanics, and much more, went from Vienna to Graz to Vienna and back to Graz during 1866-76! After more stops, he reached Vienna from thence to Leipzig in 1900 and back to Vienna in 1902 even before the position he left vacant could be filled---coming back to become his own successor. He remarked on this retrain: “One usually starts out one’s inaugural lecture with a paean praising one’s predecessor. Today, however, I can fortunately spare myself this oft-challenging task, for the fact is, I am my own predecessor.” To tie him down this time, Boltzmann was made to pledge to the Austrian emperor to never again take up a position abroad.

When the talk turns to marital longevity, the eight marriages of Elizabeth Taylor is always mentioned. It wasn't much different in our neck of the woods though. Newspaperman R.K. Dalmia, even as he needled Nehru, married six times, three of which were concurrent. Minoo Masani, Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha to Nehru, was more colourful. He first married Englishwoman Phyllis Atkinson; she quickly returned to England after at least one known affair with a Mr Fraser. Later Masani got his revenge by having an affair with Mrs. Fraser. Next, Masani courted Dady Wadia whose husband sued for divorce and custody of the children in the case *Wadia vs Wadia & Masani*. Masani later married Dady, but she began having second thoughts about this second marriage and went back to live with her ex-husband. The tables were now turned; Minoo sued Dady for adultery in *Masani vs Masani & Wadia*. During the hearing on this, the exasperated judge asked Dady, “Mrs Masani, or should I call you Mrs. Wadia, are you quite sure you know who you’re divorcing and whom you’re marrying?” *De ja vu* all over again; Dady and Minoo had done a Boltzman. Minoo married for a third time and was said to have had many a dalliance.

So, when that uncle says ‘in my time, it wasn’t so,’ I just think: “same plot, different movie.”